Lesson 2.1: Anatomy of an effective prompt

Claude Certified Associate – Foundations (CCAO-F) · Module 2: Prompting & Task Execution · Lesson 1 (the first lesson of Module 2) · 15:39

Description

Same request, same file, same model: one vague line gets a report full of jargon, and a prompt built in six parts gets an update a beginner can read. This lesson teaches those six parts, task, context, audience, constraints, format and examples, and the question each one answers. You see where the guidance comes from: the official exam guide, Anthropic's official prep course, the Claude Platform Docs, Claude 101 and the AI Fluency course. Then two real jobs from this course run in Claude Desktop, each twice. A business task: a short progress update from a real production log, first as one vague line, then rebuilt in six labelled lines, with the arithmetic checked. A technical task: one terminal command that measures the loudness of a finished lesson video, first as a vague question, then rebuilt, copied into a terminal and run. The lesson ends with one exam-style scenario, reasoned out loud, and the cue to this lesson's quick check.

Learning outcomes

By the end of this lesson you can:

1. Name the six parts of an effective prompt and the question each one answers.
2. Rebuild a vague prompt into a complete one, for a business task and a technical task.
3. Spot which missing part caused a weak answer, and fix that part.

Chapters

Time	Chapter
00:00	Preview and outcomes
00:37	Why it matters
01:29	The six parts
03:20	Straight from the source
05:28	Hands-on: a business task, a technical task
13:46	Exam angle
14:56	Recap and quick check

The six parts

The six parts are this course's structure, built from Anthropic's guidance. They are not an Anthropic list, and the exam never asks you to name "the six parts".

Part	The question it answers	In the lesson's business prompt
Task	What exactly should Claude produce?	"Write a short progress update that says Module 1 of my video course is finished."
Context	What's the situation, and why?	What the course is for, and that the attached log is a production log full of technical checks
Audience	Who will read or use it?	People who have never used AI, so no technical jargon
Constraints	What limits apply?	Under 120 words; only facts from the log; what each lesson teaches, not how it was checked; "leave it out rather than guess"
Format	What shape comes back?	A headline, one line per lesson with its length in minutes, one closing line
Examples	Can I show one?	One example line in `<example>` tags, for a lesson that isn't part of the update, so Claude copies the shape, not the content

How to lay a prompt out:

- Put a short label at the start of each line (Task:, Context:, and so on).
- Wrap pasted material or an example in XML tags, such as `<example>...</example>`.
- Say what to do, not what not to do.
- Give Claude permission to say it doesn't know, instead of guessing.
- **The golden rule** (Claude Platform Docs): would a colleague with minimal context on the task know what to do? If they'd be confused, Claude will be too.
- **Don't over-engineer.** A quick question needs one line. The six parts are a checklist, not a quota.
- **Examples:** start with one (one-shot). Add a few (few-shot) only if the answer still misses. Claude follows examples closely, so make them match the shape you want.

Linked to Lesson 0.2 (our grouping, not Anthropic's): task, audience, format and examples describe the **product**; context and constraints guide the **process**; a line like "leave it out rather than guess" sets the **performance**. Anthropic's AI Fluency course defines

Product Description as "outputs, format, audience, and style".

Straight from the source (what the lesson shows)

- **Exam guide, page 4:** Domain 1, Prompting and Task Execution (14% of scored items). Its first bullet: "Create effective prompts for business and technical tasks". This course labels it task 1.1. The guide lists its task statements as unnumbered bullets, so 1.1 is this course's label, not the guide's.
- **Exam guide, page 2:** the target candidate can, among other things, "create structured prompts" and "adapt outputs for different audiences".
- **Anthropic's official prep course, Prompting & Task Execution:** the tagline (a repeatable structure that anyone can build); "When phrased differently, Claude produces material at varying quality levels for the same request"; Description is "the backbone of this module"; learning objective 1 is this lesson's task statement.
- **Claude Platform Docs, Prompting best practices:** be clear and direct; Claude as "a brilliant but new employee who lacks context"; the golden rule; "Be specific about the desired output format and constraints"; add context (explaining why helps Claude understand your goals); use examples effectively (relevant, diverse, structured, in `<example>` tags); XML tags help Claude parse prompts that mix instructions, context, examples and pasted material.
- **Claude Academy, Claude 101, Getting better results:** the troubleshooting table. Too generic: add your audience, role or constraints. Too long or too short: state the length. Wrong format: show, don't just tell; give an example.
- **Claude Academy, AI Fluency, lessons 8 and 9:** Product Description, and six techniques: give context, show examples, specify constraints, break tasks into steps (Lesson 2.2), ask the AI to think first, define its role.

Key terms

- **Prompt:** everything you give Claude for one request: your words, plus anything you attach or paste.
- **Context:** the background Claude can't know: the situation, why you need the result, how it will be used.
- **Audience:** who will read or use the result. It sets the words, the depth and the tone.
- **Constraints:** limits the result must respect: length, sources, what to leave out, what must not change.
- **Example (one-shot, few-shot):** a sample of the output you want. One example is one-shot; a few is few-shot. Claude follows examples closely.
- **XML tags:** labels like `<example>...</example>` that mark where pasted material or an example starts and ends.

What happened in the hands-on

Claude Desktop on Linux, Chat view, Sonnet 5.5 at Medium, recorded on 2026-10-04 on a real account. Every prompt went into a new **incognito chat** (Lesson 1.4), which isn't saved and uses no memory, so the only input was the prompt and the attached file. The exact prompts, the attached log and Claude's four replies are in the student kit.

Business task: a progress update for people following the course. The attachment is the real course log for Module 1: the syllabus rows plus one production-log line per lesson, packed with technical checks and jargon.

1. **Vague prompt:** "Write an update about my course from this log." Claude had to guess who it was for, how long, and what mattered. It wrote a thorough producer's report: a headline, a date, a table of lessons, then "Quality checks", "Open items" and "Next steps", full of jargon a beginner can't use.
2. **One real misreading.** The table has a "Finished" column: Lesson 1.1, runtime 11:56, finished 11:55. In the log, 11:55 is the length itself (11 minutes 55 seconds, 715.7 s). Claude had to guess what the numbers meant, and guessed wrong. Nothing was broken; the prompt never said who the update was for.
3. **Rebuilt prompt,** in a fresh incognito chat with the same log attached the same way, so only the prompt changed: six labelled lines, read as they were typed.
4. **The result:** a headline, "Module 1 is finished", one line per lesson in the example's exact shape (lesson, minutes, what it teaches), and the log's own closing line, "Next up: the Module 1 quiz." It copied the example's shape, not its content.
5. **Checked:** 88 words (under 120), every fact from the log. The minutes were arithmetic, so one was verified: Lesson 1.4 ran 812.6 seconds, about 13.5 minutes; the update says 14, rounded up, correct. The other three (715.7, 718.8, 762.5 s → 12, 12, 13 min) check out too. That's Discernment (Lesson 0.2).
6. **Side by side,** every difference traces to a part that was added: the audience removed the jargon, the constraints set the length and content, the format and example set the shape, and a clear format left no "Finished" column to misread.

Technical task: measure the loudness of a finished lesson video. Every finished lesson in this course has a loudness target (about -16 LUFS, true peak around -3 dBTP). LUFS is a unit for how loud audio sounds to a listener; the exam won't ask about it.

7. **Vague prompt:** "How do I check the loudness of my video?" A solid general answer with a generic command (placeholder file name "video.mp4"), other tools, four video editors and a table of common targets, because it didn't know the file, the system, the target or the user. It ended by asking for the missing context: where you're publishing and what editor you use.
8. **Rebuilt prompt,** in a fresh incognito chat: task (one terminal command), context (the target, Linux, FFmpeg installed, the exact file path), audience (not a developer, first time in a terminal), constraints (only read the video, never change or overwrite it; FFmpeg only; short output), format (one code block, one line per part, which two numbers to read), and one example explanation line.
9. **The answer:** one command, explained part by part in the example's shape. `-f null -` sends the result nowhere, so no new file is created and the video is never touched: the read-only constraint, explained before anything runs.
10. **The proof:** the command was copied with the Copy button, pasted into a terminal that had been opened before recording, read once more, and run. FFmpeg read the whole video (about 13.5 minutes of sound) in a few seconds and printed only the summary: **Input**

Integrated -16.0 LUFS, Input True Peak -3.0 dBTP, both on target and both exactly what the production log says for Lesson 1.4. The Output lines describe a correction this command doesn't apply, so, as the reply said, they're ignored.

The exam link

Domain 1, Prompting and Task Execution (14% of scored items). This lesson serves the bullet this course labels **1.1**: "Create effective prompts for business and technical tasks". The guide lists its task statements as unnumbered bullets; the number 1.1 is this course's label. The next lessons cover the other three Domain 1 bullets, starting with breaking tasks into steps in Lesson 2.2.

The lesson's practice scenario (original, written for this course, not from the exam). An operations coordinator asks Claude for a formula that flags late orders. The formula uses columns her sheet doesn't have, and calls any order late if it ships after the order date. Her team's rule: more than three business days. What's the most appropriate next step? A: switch to the most capable model. B: ask for a double-check, with a confidence rating. C: rewrite the prompt with her real column names, the team's definition of late, her spreadsheet app, and one example row with the expected result. D: add "You are a world-class spreadsheet expert. Be accurate." The answer is **C**. Ask what was missing: not intelligence, information. Claude never saw her columns or her rule. A spends a bigger model on the same missing facts. B asks for a self-grade, and the exam guide says self-reported confidence isn't a reliable signal of accuracy. D adds a role, but no facts. C adds exactly what was missing: context, a constraint and an example.

Quick check

Before you move on, take this lesson's quick check: a few short questions, a couple of minutes. The exam-style question in this lesson, the quick checks, the module quizzes and the practice exams are all original, written for this course against the official blueprint. They are never copies of the real exam.

Sources (all checked 2026-10-04)

- **Anthropic, *Claude Certified Associate – Foundations Exam Guide*.** Version 1.0, effective July 2026. §3 target candidate (p. 2), §6 Domain 1 (p. 4), §7 How to Prepare. Official download: https://everpath-course-content.s3-accelerate.amazonaws.com/instructor/6nizmqk8tpzpfjvt6qmmav7rh/public/1783542847/Claude+Certified+Associate+%E2%80%93+Foun
- **Anthropic's official CCAO-F prep course,** Course 2, *Prompting & Task Execution* (public course page: tagline, About this course, learning objective 1).
- **Claude Platform Docs,** *Prompting best practices* (be clear and direct; add context; use examples effectively; structure prompts with XML tags; control the format of responses): https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/build-with-claude/prompt-engineering/claude-prompting-best-practices
- **Claude blog,** *Best practices for prompt engineering* (November 10, 2025: start with one example; give permission to express uncertainty; don't over-engineer): https://claude.com/blog/best-practices-for-prompt-engineering
- **Claude Academy, Claude 101:** *Your first conversation with Claude*: https://academy.claude.com/courses/claude-101/your-first-conversation-with-claude and *Getting better results*: https://academy.claude.com/courses/claude-101/getting-better-results
- **Claude Academy, AI Fluency: Framework and foundations:** *A closer look at Description*: https://academy.claude.com/courses/ai-fluency-framework-foundations/a-closer-look-at-description and *Effective prompting techniques*: https://academy.claude.com/courses/ai-fluency-framework-foundations/effective-prompting-techniques
- **FFmpeg filters documentation** (ebur128, loudnorm): https://ffmpeg.org/ffmpeg-filters.html. The run used FFmpeg 6.1.1 on Linux.
- **The app itself:** Claude Desktop on Linux, Chat view, Sonnet 5.5 Medium, incognito chats, observed 2026-10-04. Menus and labels can change between versions.

The six parts, the product/process/performance grouping and the business and technical prompts are this course's own teaching tools, built from the sources above. The hands-on material is real: the course's own production log and a finished lesson video of this course.

What you see in the lesson is a real account. Settings, Account and Memory were never opened. A usage notice that Claude Desktop showed during recording is blurred.